

The Past Master

› As Union home secretary, Kumar helped draft the law that paved the way for the abrogation of Article 370 and J&K's reorganisation in 2019

› He also steered the government's legal and administrative preparations during the Ram Temple litigation, later playing a central role in setting up the trust that oversaw the temple's construction

of accusation and counter-accusation. Rahul demanded machine-readable voter lists for independent audits. Kumar retorted that the claims were "false and misleading" and that the commission would not publish editable data at the expense of voter privacy. He challenged the Opposition to file affidavits proving fraud or apologise. Through it all, Kumar's public persona hardened: authoritative, dismissive of questions on the integrity of the commission.

It was the Bihar assembly election, however, that offered his administration a more empirical verdict. In a sharp departure from India's multi-phase elections, Kumar compressed the Bihar polls into just two phases, citing better logistics and security. The gamble paid off. Turnout crossed 67 per cent, women voted in record numbers; no party or candidate demanded any repoll, a rare achievement.

By year's end, Kumar's arc extended well beyond India's electoral calendar. In December, he took charge as Chair of International IDEA, the Stockholm-based intergovernmental body devoted to strengthening democratic institutions worldwide. His role served as a soft-power validation of India's election management prowess. Yet his work at home remains unfinished. Having piloted the SIR in Bihar, Kumar now faces the more complex task of completing similar revisions across other states, an undertaking that becomes politically combustible before elections. ■